

On the Crest

Tomas Rodriguez

Note to the reader:

This story is about Aspen, a woman going through her transition. Her name before transition was Asher, which will be used throughout as well, as she comes to terms with herself. But all action lines will refer to her as her actual name. ASPEN.

1 EXT. PACIFIC CREST TRAIL - DAY

Wide landscape of large grey mountains sticking up like sharks fins in a sea of trees. It's quiet and birds can be heard chirping. The breeze blowing lightly swaying the trees, back and forth... back and forth.

Faintly in the background 'stupid stupid stupid' can be heard... A squirrel perches up on a rock in the foreground, trying to crack a nut open.

A small rock is hurled towards it. It runs away.

We now see ASPEN, 20, short brown hair to her shoulders, an olive green jacket, grey khakis, and tennis shoes. She's wearing a giant backpack, with hanging mugs, and shirts. She looks mad, kicking rocks off the ground. Rocks flying out into the valley, hitting trees, the sound getting softer and softer as it falls. She kicks a rock towards a tree, and when placing her foot down, steps on a loose stone slab, and trips, landing on a larger rock, with her backpack taking the hit.

POP!

She falls hard. Taking off her pack she gets up and checks her body. Small scrapes on her forearms and elbows, dirt in her face. Her backpack begins to drip water unto the ground, a puddle grows. Aspen notices it and begins to open her bag

ASPEN

Fuck! Fuck! Fuck! No! No!, please not right now! Please!

She shuffles through her back pack, taking out all her clothes, food, tools. She takes out a blue bag filled with little water. A massive hole right through the middle. The water left is dripping out slowly.

ASPEN

DAMN IT!

Aspen throws the broken bag on the ground.

ASPEN
(really pissed)
YOU FUCKING IDIOT! AHHH!

She kicks a tree, over, and over, and over again.

ASPEN
YOU FUCKING MORON! You do this every
time! You useless-

BANG! A gunshot is heard and Aspen falls to the ground.

CUT TO:

2 EXT. MCDONALD'S SIDEWALK - NIGHT

Aspen sits on the curb, holding out her finger. She's eating a burger. Next to her her giant backpack, sagging to one side. The sound of cars swooshing by, one after another. Not many on the road, but they seem to always come in pairs or triplets.

Aspen puts her burger on her legs, and reaches into her pocket, taking out her phone.

She scrolls through her contacts until stopping at LILLI, and ringing her. Her profile picture shows the two of them, standing at the top of a mountain, looking over the valley. Aspen holds the phone up to her ear.

RING RING RING RING RING RING RING RIN- Aspen waits.

LILLI (O.S.)
Hey Aspen, whats up.

ASPEN
Just wanted to make sure you got my
message... You didn't respond.

Aspen awaits a response. A beat.

LILLI (O.S.)
Now I have.

ASPEN
Do you have a stereo speaker?

LILLI (O.S.)
Yeh.

ASPEN

Play it though that, it will sound more believable.

LILLI (O.S.)

How long will you be gone?

ASPEN

A few months, maybe longer.

LILLI (O.S.)

What do I say if he shows up?

A white electric Chevrolet pulls out of the street, parking right in front of Aspen, the headlights blinding her. Aspen lowers the phone from her ear.

LILLI (O.S.)

(faintly in the background)

Aspen? Hello! Asss-peeene?

The man sticks his head out the car window.

MAN

Need a ride?

Aspen turns to look at him.

ASPEN

Yeah! That would be great. Thank you!

Holding up the phone to her ear.

ASPEN (CONT'D)

I have to go. Talk later.

LILLI

How-

She hangs up the phone, and in the process knocks over her burger into the gutter. Floating on a thin layer of brown water. She sighs, she was gonna finish that.

Aspen gets up, looks down at the burger, floating, as the bun breaks apart and gets sucked down the gutter. She looks at her bag, noticing some clothes hanging out the side, one with a floral pattern. She quickly shoves them back into the bag, and out of site.

She kneels in front of her bag. Puts her arms around the handle, and pushes herself, up.

ASPEN
(under her breath)
One... Two... and Three!

She rises slowly pushing hard as the weight of bag sags her down.

She walks over to the car. The man gets out of the car, and walks around the back of the car. The man looks in his late 50's, a short beard, and trimmed mustache. He's wearing rubber boots, a plaid button up, and dark blue pants with suspenders.

MAN
Quite the load... You can put it back here.

The man opens the trunk.

ASPEN
Big bag.

Aspen yawns, and drops her bag onto the car, a thud as it hits.

MAN
What are you carrying in there, rocks?

Aspen takes off her sweater and shoves it into the bags side pocket.

ASPEN
Boulders.

The man chuckles a little.

ASPEN
Thank you for stopping. Been waiting for around half an hour.

MAN
Happy to help. Where you headed?

ASPEN
Campo, or around there. I understand if it's not on your way. Really anywhere further down east will help me plenty.

MAN
I'm headed that way, not all the way,

but I'll see what I can do...
(gesturing with his hands)
Hop in.

The man walks to the driver seat and Aspen goes the other way. They hop in the car. Both people close their doors, the car rattling a little, side to side.

CUT TO:

3 INT. CAR INTERIOR - NIGHT

The car interior is nice, a PCT crest hangs from the rear view mirror. A large pink water bottle at Aspens feet.

MAN
Ohh sorry, let me get that.

The man reaches over to try and grab the bottle, but his arms don't reach. Aspen grabs it and hands it to him.

MAN
Thanks.

He throws the bottle to the back seats. He inserts the key, and ignites the engine.

MAN
Almost forgot, where are my manners,
I'm Nathan.

The man extends his hand for a handshake. Aspen briefly hesitates.

ASPEN
I'm Asher, nice to meet you.

Aspen shakes his hand. NATHAN changes the gear, and pulls out onto the desolate road.

ASPEN
I could pay you if you need, I don't
mind, really.

NATHAN
No need, don't have much to do
regardless.

ASPEN
Drop me off wherever works, ill find a
way to make it the rest of the way.

NATHAN
I'll take you there, not a problem.
(pause)
What brings you out here? Can't
imagine you're a tourist with that
size backpack.

ASPEN
Wanted to get away from home... do my
own thing...

NATHAN
You homeless?

ASPEN
No... well... not yet.

Nathan chuckles lightly. Silence hits the car, the two sit
there staring at the road.

ASPEN
Have you done the PCT?

NATHAN
The what?

ASPEN
P-C-T.
(pointing at the PCT crest)
Saw that and thought you'd might have
done it.

NATHAN
OHH, no I haven't, that was my wife's.

ASPEN
Did she like it?

NATHAN
She loved it, it was her favorite
thing.

ASPEN
How long ago did she do it?

NATHAN
What was it... like... three years
ago. Started in May.

ASPEN
How long did it take her?

NATHAN

She walked slow, took her time...

Nathan almost begins to tear, his voice is softly shaken.

NATHAN

...But she never made it... last time
I saw her I spit at her, yelled at
her, told her she was selfish. What
did I know... I never understood her,
until it was too late.

ASPEN

I'm sorry...

NATHAN

It's alright...

Nathan holds his hand to his heart.

NATHAN (CONT'D)

She's in here now. With me all the
time.

Nathan wipes his eyes, before a tear can come out.

ASPEN

If you're alright telling me, how did
she die?

NATHAN

No problem. A hiker found her on the
edge of the trail, her body covered in
scratches. Her body bruised.

NATHAN (CONT'D)

They couldn't do much, but reported it
once they reached the nearest restock
point.

(mini pause)

By the time they brought people to
take her body out, it was gone. An
animal probably ate her. A mountain
lion I hope... A burial she would
approve of.

They sit in silence. Aspen yawns.

NATHAN

Tired?

ASPEN

Yeah.

NATHAN

Sleep, I'll let you know when we arrive.

ASPEN

Thanks.

Aspen takes her jacket off, bundles it and uses it as a pillow against the car window. Nathan stares at the road ahead. A beat. Nathan lightly gasps

NATHAN

Are you doing the PCT?

No response. Nathan looks over, and sees Aspen has fallen asleep. Her head rested on the window. He smiles, and looks back to the road.

CUT TO:

4 EXT. GAS STATION - MORNING

Deserted slopping hills tower a small gas station. Chaparral dots the landscape. The white car pulls into the gas station. Parking next to a "gas thing". Nathan pops the gas tab, and gets out of the car.

CUT TO:

5 INT. CAR INTERIOR - CONTINUED

Aspen is still sleeping, now covered by a blanket. Her head resting on the window.

BUZZZ BUZZZZ BUZZZZZ BUZZZZZ

Aspen startles awake from the buzzing feeling. Reaches for her pockets, she locates the buzzing. Pulling out her phone looking at it. CAMERA cannot see phone screen. She cancels the call, swipes at her phone. She puts her phone in her pocket.

Looking up, confusion creeps up her face, "where am I?". Then she remembers. She looks around, seeing Nathan through the window inserting the "gas fill tube", selecting the gas. He walks back and opens the door.

NATHAN
(apologetically warm)
Oh, sorry. I didn't mean to wake you.

ASPEN
Had just woken up.

Nathan opens a compartment on the left side of the steering wheel. Aspen can see him taking out cash.

NATHAN
(relieved)
There it is! Thank god.

He takes out a ring, looks at it and puts it in his breast pocket. He puts the cash into his wallet. He turns to Aspen.

NATHAN
I was gonna buy you something, but
seeing as you're awake.

ASPEN
Sure.

CUT TO:

6 INT. GAS STATION STORE - CONTINUED

DING!

Aspen and Nathan walk into the store. It looks like a standard convenience store, multi colored aisles, the cashier, and the ICEE machine in the back.

NATHAN
What do you want?

ASPEN
Can you get me a coke?

NATHAN
Alright.

ASPEN

Wait! some M&M's as well.
Thank you.

Nathan nods and walks down an aisle, and CAMERA follows Aspen as she walks to the back of the store, walking into the men's restroom. Nathan walks up to the cashier, placing down a bottle of coke, a can of monster, a bag of M&M's, and two bags of beef jerky.

CASHIER
Will that be all?

NATHAN
Yes.

PUNCH PNCH PONCH PENCH PINTCH PUNCH (cashier tapping keys)

Nathan is counting the bills in his wallet.

CASHIER
Seventeen, twenty nine. Cash or credit.

NATHAN
Umm... credit.

Nathan hands the cashier his card. She points to the machine. He slides his card.

CASHIER
Try again, it didn't go through.

Nathan swipes it again.

CASHIER
Nothing

Aspen walks up to the counter.

NATHAN
Hey, do you happen to have any money.

ASPEN
Yeah.

Aspen unzips her wallet open, taking out a twenty. She hands it to the cashier. She grabs the bill and pops open the machine.

NATHAN
(handing Aspen the money)
Here's fifteen. I haven't used that card in years, figures its empty.

ASPEN
You're good. You took me all the way here.

CASHIER
Two, seventy one.

The cashier places the money in Aspen's hands. She takes the penny and places it in the tip jar.

ASPEN
(lightly nodding)
Have a good day.

CASHIER
You too.

As they walk away Aspen grabs a "thing of gum" and puts it in his wallet along with the bills. They open the door

DING!

CUT TO:

7 INT. BEDROOM - MORNING

The sound of a shower is heard. The room has beige walls, a queen bed, with sheets all crumpled. A dark blue suit with light blue pattern hangs on a door. There are multiple pairs of shoes lined up next to the door.

The shower is heard turning off. TAYLOR walks out. A man in his late 40's, short brown hair, short fuzzy beard. He has a towel wrapped around his waist. He walks over to his night stand, opens a drawer. He ruffles through the thing inside.

TAYLOR
Damn it, where is it.?

He opens the other drawers. Nothing. Walks over to his closet, opening all the drawers.

TAYLOR
Asher! Have you seen my wallet!?

Silence. He walks out of the room.

CUT TO:

8 INT. HOUSE HALLWAY - CONTINUED

Taylor walks down to a door on the other end of the hallway.

KNOCK KNOCK!! A beat. KNOCK!! KNOCK!!

NATHAN
Asher?

He waits for a moment... No response. He opens the door.

The room is pristine, the bed well made, a wall of well organized posters on the wall above a small wooden desk. But no one's in the room. He walks in and goes to the bathroom, opening the door. Empty.

CUT TO:

9 INT. KITCHEN - CONTINUED

Taylor walks down the stairs to the kitchen. Nothing. He takes out his phone, scrolls. Puts the phone to his ear.

RING RING RING RING Voicemail

He cancels the call. Swiping around on his phone, and dialing someone else.

RING RING RING RING RIN-

TAYLOR
Lillian?

LILLI (O.S.)
Hello Mr.Green.

TAYLOR
(forced gentleness)
Hi Lilli. Did Asher come over to your house? He's not here.

LILLI (O.S.)
Yeh... Ill hand the phone over.

Taylor awaits for a response, a bit impatient.

ASPEN (O.S.)
Hey Dad, Im staying over at Lilli's place for a few days. I start working next week, that sushi place near the old timey movie theater.

TAYLOR
Wheres my walle-

ASPEN (O.S. CONT'D)
I dont have it, have you checked underneath the dresser, or behind the coffee machine?

TAYLOR
I wil-

ASPEN (O.S. CONT'D)
Love you dad. Bye.

The line cuts out. Taylor is a little annoyed, but shakes it off.

He walks to his dresser, crouching down, looking underneath.

CUT TO:

10 EXT. DIRT ROAD - DAY

The white Chevy drives down a barren road, no building in site. Flat rolling hills covered in yellow grass, and bushes. A tall, red, barred wall is the only structure in sight, the Mexico-U.S. border.

Before hitting the wall, the car turn left.

CUT TO:

11 INT. CAR INTERIOR - CONTINUED

ASPEN
I don't think you can drive on here.

NATHAN
It's alright no one is here. Besides
if there were people, who gives a
fuck.

ASPEN
(worried)
You never know.

NATHAN
The trail starts right there.

Nathan points to a set of stone pillars, small no taller than Aspen. Nathan stops the car, parks. He gets out, Aspen follows suit.

CUT TO:

12 EXT. DIRT ROAD - CONTINUED

Nathan pops the trunk open. Aspen pulls her bag to the edge of the car, puts her arms through the straps.

ASPEN
(almost to herself)
One, two, three and up.

She stands up, lifting the backpack up onto her back.

NATHAN
You sure you don't want to leave
anything here. You could reach out
once your done.

ASPEN
It's alright, thank you.

NATHAN
As you wish.

Nathan thinks, then his face turns on.

NATHAN
OHH! I forgot, I wanted to give you
something, gimme a second.

Nathan runs back to the front seat, grabbing something. He comes back. He hands her his PCT crest.

NATHAN
I want you to have it.

ASPEN
No, no I can't.

NATHAN
(giving it to her again)
Please. I insisit.

ASPEN
It was your wife's. I can't take that
from you.

NATHAN
She would have wanted you to have it.

Aspen reluctantly agrees, grabbing the patch and staring at it.

NATHAN

You send it to me when you done. You
have my address.

(mini pause)

She'll always be with you.

ASPEN

Thank you.

She puts the patch in her pocket. She sits in silence for a
moment.

ASPEN

Can... Can I hug you?

Nathan opens up his arm, and Aspen hugs him, squeezing hard.
Nathan doesn't expect the squeeze, but he smiles.

ASPEN

(stops hugging)

Thank you for everything.

NATHAN

See you in a few months.

They wave each other goodbye, as Aspen walks down the dirt
path, starting her journey. Nathan notices some gloves inside
his car. Black leather gloves with fur on the rim.

NATHAN

Asher, you left these.

Nathan holds up the gloves. Aspen walks back, to see what
he's holding.

ASPEN

Oh, those aren't mine.

(lying)

I wouldn't buy gloves like that.

NATHAN

Hmmn, wonder whose they are.

THUMP! Nathan closes the trunk.

Looking at the gloves he sees a name on the inside. ASPEN

CUT TO:

13 INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

A room with a large window facing the street. Two large leather couches facing each other. Sitting down, facing away from the window is HAZEL. A woman in her mid-30's, short hair down to her shoulders. She's wearing a pastel purple sweater, with skinny jeans, and converse. She's on her phone, fiddling with the end of her glasses in her mouth.

Through the window a teenager can be seen walking up to the door and opening. The door opens, the teenager is ASPEN, 16, she is wearing green sweat pants, and a baggy hoodie.

HAZEL

Hey sweetie, how was practice?

Aspen doesn't turn to look at her mom.

ASPEN

It was fun.

Aspen walks up the stair in a rush.

WHAM!! A door closes shut.

Hazel rolls her eyes in a gentle manner. Hazel stands up, grabs her empty cup of coffee and walks towards the kitchen.

CUT TO:

14 INT. ASPEN'S BEDROOM - CONTINUED

Aspen walks into her room, locking the door behind her. The room is the same furniture as when she's older. But there's nothing on the walls except for a poster for "Princess Mononoke".

She walks over to her bed and places her backpack on it. She takes out a small black dress with little red roses on it, and a pair of grey socks. She searches the bag looking for something. She can't find it. Aspen turns around and walks out of her room.

CUT TO:

15 INT. PARENTS BEDROOM - CONTINUED

Aspen walks into another bedroom. She walks over to a large dark pale blue dresser, opening the bottom drawer.

Inside is a bunch of different scarves, socks, and a black pair of leather gloves. The same pair Nathan found in his car.

CUT TO:

16 INT. ASPEN'S BEDROOM - CONTINUED

Aspen walks back into her room, forgetting to lock the door.

She places the gloves on the bed, and starts to take her clothes off, leaving only her underwear.

She grabs the dress, holding it up, the light coming from the window shining through. She looks for the opening, sliding over her head, putting it on like a t-shirt. She puts the socks on, stretching them all the way up to her knees.

She walks over to the mirror, standing tall, staring at herself. She spins around, seeing herself in the mirror as the dress lifts up. She grabs the glove puts on the gloves. Looking in the mirror, she smiles. She stares at herself. Smiling.

CHAAK! The door handle moves down, the door opening.

ASPEN
WAIT MOM! Im changin-

Hazel walks into the room.

ASPEN
MOM!

Aspen bolts to the bathroom, shutting the door behind her. Hazel walks over to the door, lightly knocking

Knock Knock

HAZEL
I'm sorry sweetie. I should have
knocked.

No response.

HAZEL
Asher? Can I come in?

Silence. Hazel sighs, and sits down on the floor, facing the door.

HAZEL
I'm not mad.

ASPEN
(softly)
That's not true.

HAZEL
Talk to me. What's going on?

Silence. Hazel put her hand on the door.

HAZEL
Sweetie, I love you.

Hazel waits for a response.

HAZEL
I won't tell your Dad anything.
(some worry)
Come on sweetie, come out. Talk to me,
I'm here for you I promise. Whatever
you need.

A long silence. Hazel opens her mouth, like she's about to say something.

ASPEN
Can you pass me my shirt and pants?

HAZEL
Sure, wh-

ASPEN
They are on my bed.

Hazel stands up, walking over to the bed. Grabbing the clothes and walks back to the bathroom door. brings them to the door.

HAZEL
Here

Aspen cracks the door open very little. Grabs the clothes and quickly shuts the door. Hazel sits there is silent, faint sounds of ruffling and moving is heard.

WAOSSSHHHHHOOSH... The toilet flushes.

HAZEL
Asher?

Hazel puts her ear on the door, listening.

Aspen opens the door, bolting out and jumping into her bed. Covering herself up, hiding under the covers. She begins to cry.

Hazel peers into the bathroom. The clothes Aspen had on are swirling in the toilet bowl. She grabs them, ringing them out in the bathtub. Placing them on the shower curtain pole. She walks over to Aspen's bed. Sitting down and placing her hand on top of the mound in the middle of the bed.

HAZEL
Sweetie talk to me. Where'd you get
those clothes?

Aspen curls into a tighter ball. Hazel peels the blankets off, revealing Aspen's head.

Hazel leans in giving her a kiss on the cheek. Then putting her arms under her and picking her up, hugging her. Aspen begins crying harder. Beginning to hyperventilate.

HAZEL
Come here my baby.

Hazel begins rocking Aspen lightly, back and forth.

HAZEL (CONT'D)
I love you.

They sit in silence, Hazel slowly rocking Aspen, like when she was a baby. A beat.

Hazel stops, and holds her by shoulders. Aspen looks away.

HAZEL
(soft and warm)
Look at me.

Aspen hesitates, wiping a tear from her face.

Aspen turns to look at her mom.

HAZEL
Breath... In...

Hazel takes a deep breath, Aspen follows slowly after.

HAZEL (CONT'D)
And out...

They breath out together.

HAZEL (CONT'D)

Perfect.

Aspen continues breathing, slowly. Calming her breathing to a steady rate. Hazel stares at Aspen, a big smile on her face.

HAZEL

You looked beautiful.

A tear rolls down Aspen's face. She goes in to hug her mom, squeezing hard and smiling.

CUT TO:

17 EXT. TRAIL - DUSK

The sun is low in the sky, casting an orange blanket across the landscape.

Aspen is sitting down in her sleeping bag eating from a bag. She has made a small fire surrounded by rocks. She has her headphone in, her body moving to the rhythm of the song, whistling along. Her phone is on her lap. To her right is a kettle, she reaches for it extending herself. Her feet get closer to the fire.

Her phone falls off her lap, hitting the ground. She ignores it reaching for the kettle, filling up her bag with a little more water. Her feet begin to feel hot. She looks towards her feet to see the sleeping bag has caught fire. She quickly rushes to get out of the sack, tossing everything and pushing it off her.

Once she's out she tries to grab the sleeping bag, but she pushed it more towards the fire and when she takes it out, one third is already a flame.

ASPEN

OWW, FUCK!

She has no way of putting it out, its too big and any effort now would be in vain. She stares at the burning sack. Sadness and rage in her eyes.

ASPEN

FUCK! GOD DAMMIT!

She tosses it back into the fire.

ASPEN
 AHH! STUPID! STUPID!

BANG! a gunshot is heard, and Aspen drops to the ground. Aspen can be seen holding the gun, standing above her body.

She snaps out of it. She's back to where she was before. Taking a deep long breath, and out. She grabs her phone off the ground. Walking over to the tent, and going inside.

On the roof of the tent she has a hanging flashlight which she turns on. On the floor is a thin inflatable cushion, a makeshift pillow, the bag of her sleeping bag stuffed with things, and her backpack, which she opens.

She starts to take things out, one by one. A shirt, a plastic bag with things, deodorant, pajama pants, underwear, more shirts. She looks at her phone, places the earbuds in her ears, and presses play. (We can hear it)

SONG: "Madre" by Silvio Rodriguez, and Pablo Milanés

She changes her shirt, and reaches for the pajama pants. She hesitates and reaches over for the plastic bag, looking inside. Inside is a long white skirt, with colorful lines and patterns of flowers and leaves.

She takes it out and holds it up, staring at it. She stands up, as best she can, and takes off her pants, and puts the skirt on. She sits back down, laying down on her back with knees bent. She smiles. Two beats.

She reaches for her stack of jackets in the corner, grabbing a big one and covering herself. Closing her eyes. CAMERA stays on her face till the song ends.

18 EXT. TRAIL - DAY

Aspen is asleep, curled up in a ball. Covered by all her jackets. Only the sound of crickets chirping can be heard. A faint sound is heard, growing.

CHRAK CHII CHIAK CHRAK CHIAK CHRAK CHII CHIAK

Footstep on the gravel can be heard. CAMERA stays inside the tent, looking at Aspen.

MAN #1
 (faintly at first, grow louder)
 ...down by Idyllwild, three of them.

MAN #2
On accident.

MAN #1
I don't know, what if they are
murders.

MAN #2
You thin-

MAN #1
Think we ask them for food?

MAN #2
I don't know... How far is it to Big
Bear?

MAN #1
Twenty six, twenty seven, somewhere
around there.

MAN #2
Then lets go for it.

Aspen slowly shifts awake.

MAN #1
H-

MAN #2
(quietly)
Wait, what if they're asleep.

MAN #1
At this point, were doing them a favor
waking them up.
(in a louder voice, not shouting)
Hello in there, do you happen to have
any food?

Aspen lays awake for a moment then arises.

ASPEN
Yes.

MAN #1
(surprised)
Oh.

PACKT The sound of someone getting hit can be heard.

MAN #1 (CONT'D)

Could we join you for breakfast? We could pay you.

ASPEN

It's fine, I need to lose some weight.

Aspen crawls towards the door. As she opens the door she looks down and realizes she's still wearing the skirt, panic freezes her face. She quickly zips it back up.

ASPEN

Gimme a second, I have to change.

MAN #2

No problem... Thank you.

She quickly takes the skirt off, placing it inside the plastic bag. She grabs some sweat pants, and puts them on. She grabs her slippers and walks out.

MAN #1 is ASUNCION, 27, a big guy, wearing a polo shirt and beige pants. MAN #2 is ALFREDO, a small skinny man, with muscle, wearing a tank top, shorts, and abnormally large shoes for his legs. Alfredo extends out his hand.

ALFREDO

I am Alfredo.

ASUNCION

I'm Asuncion.

She shakes their hands.

ASPEN

Nice to meet you. I'm Asher.

ALFREDO

Thank you for helping us out. We lost almost all our food last night. I think we might have left it out and animals took it. But I'm pretty sure we had it in our bear canister, so there's no way they could have reached it.

ASUNCION

It's so sad we had some amazing beef jerky, and a killer canned ramen.

ALFREDO
(friendly pushing Asuncion)
Those things are disgusting.

ASUNCION
More for me.

CUT TO:

The three of them are sitting down in a "circle". They are eating eggs with bacon from bags, and talking.

ALFREDO
(surprised)
Seriously!?

Aspen points to the charred remains of the sleeping bag.

ASPEN
Yeh. It's right over there.

ALFREDO
How did you not freeze last night?

ASPEN
I have a few jackets. Even so it's not to cold yet, in a few weeks it will not be as easy.

ASUNCION
Do you have someone that could mail you a sleeping bag. There's a mail office in Big Bear, some twenty five miles from here.

ASPEN
Nope. I don't have a phone. It died last night.
(inquisitively)
Do you guys have one I could borrow?

ASUNCION
We only have a SAT phone, but we have to change the batteries, they're all dead.

ALFREDO
(to Asuncion)
He could also go to th-
(to Aspen)
You could go to Bear Mountaineering

and Adventure. Its has everything for camping. Asuncion bought his backpack there.

ASPEN
Could you show me on a map.

ALFREDO
I think so.

Aspen stands and walks to her tent, going inside. Shortly after she comes out. She raises the map in her hand, shaking it a little. She opens it and hands it to Alfredo, staying standing, hovering over. Alfredo moves his finger along the map,

ALFREDO
(under his breath)
...uhh... is it? ...no...
(normal)
Ah-ha!

He points to a spot on the map.

ALFREDO (CONT'D)
Right here. Do you have a pen?
Something to write with?

Asuncion hands him a pen.

ALFREDO
Thank you.

He circles the spot where his finger was.

ALFREDO
That's like, 15 miles away. Shouldn't be to far off the trail.

ASPEN
Thank you.

She extends her hand and Alfredo hands her the map. She looks at it for a moment, then folds it and puts it in her back pocket.

CUT TO:

19 INT. POLICE STATION - DAY

CAMERA looks at Taylor, standing in the police office. He's

wearing the blue suit from earlier, his tie is slightly wonky, rushed. He looks annoyed.

TAYLOR

What do you mean you cant send a search team. He could have gotten bit by a snake or even fell of a cliff.

POLICE OFFICER #1

Mr. Green, there's nothing we can do. Your son is over eighteen. He has the right to go where he pleases.

TAYLOR

He's still under my protection, lives under my roof.

POLICE OFFICER #1

The best we can do for you is give you some pointers on where to start, but its not possible to open an entire case to find him.

Taylor scoffs.

TAYLOR

(under his breath, barely audible)
Unbelievable.

The door behind Taylor opens, he turns around. Another officer pokes his head in.

POLICE OFFICER #2

You called?

POLICE OFFICER #1

Yes, thanks for coming Jacob. This is Mr. Green. His son ran away and I offered him to help him get started.

(to Taylor)

Mr. Green, Officer Ramirez will help you from here.

TAYLOR

(annoyed)
Thank you.

Taylor turns around, Officer Ramirez extends his hand for a hand shake. Taylor ignores it, and walks past.

CUT TO:

20 EXT. STORE

Aspen is in the mountaineering store. There are jackets of every kind, skis, bikes, kayaks. An adventure paradise. She walks up to the cashier. In her hand she has a light green sleeping bag. Sound of the cashier's talking becomes audible as Aspen approaches

CASHIER #1

Have they caught anyone?

She places the stuff she's carrying on the counter.

CASHIER #1

(to Aspen)

Find everything all right?

ASPEN

Yes thank you.

The cashier begins scanning the items. Aspen takes out her wallet.

CASHIER #2

I think they got someone.

CASHIER #1

That will be hundred and ninety five with twelve cents. Ready whenever.

She takes out a credit card, and inserts it into the machine.

CASHIER #2

Heard he shot himself in jail.

CASHIER #1

Really didn't want to go prison

(to Aspen)

It didn't go through, you want to try again?

Short montage of Aspen trying to insert a card and failing then taking out other cards from the wallet. One after the other, failing.

CASHIER

Nope.

ASPEN

(annoyed)

It's fine, I guess I won't buy it.

Thank you though.

CASHIER

Alright. Have a good day.

The cashier takes the sleeping bag and stuffs it under the counter. Aspen walks away. She walks to the door like she's leaving but last minute turns sideways back into the store.

A beat. She turns around and goes back into the store, heading towards the wall of hanging sleeping bags. She looks back to the counter. The cashier walks through a door into the store storage.

She grabs a sleeping bag, walks over to a set of jackets and picks out a blue one. Stuffing the jacket into the sleeping bag.

Walking over to a wall of food, she picks out a few bags of dried food, stuffing them into the sleeping bag. Walking around stuffing things into the sleeping bag until it starts to look suspiciously full.

She walks along the edge of the store, towards the door. She looks forward, not straying her vision. The door approaches, not just a few steps away.

WORKER (O.S.)

Sir, can I help you?

Aspen doesn't turn to see who it is, she bolts. Rushing out of the store. The detectors are set off.

BEEEP BEEEP BEEEP BEEEP BEEEP BEEEP BEEEP BEEEP

WORKER

HEY! COME BACK! YOU HAVE TO PAY FOR THAT!

The worker runs after her, stopping at the door, not in the mood to pursuit. Aspen runs fast, through the desert. Not stopping to look back.

CUT TO:

21 EXT. TRAIL - DAY

A wide expanse of mountain painted with trails crawling on the tops. Trees still aren't tall.

Aspen is walking, whistling a tune. She notices up ahead, a

woman sitting, most likely taking a break. Aspen stops whistling as she approaches her.

The woman notices her and stands up, slowly. Raising her hand.

WOMAN
(in the background)
Ohh, bless the lords!

Aspen walks up to her, staring.

ASPEN
Hi.

WOMAN
Hey sweetie, do you happen to have some water?

Holds up her empty water bottle.

WOMAN (CONT'D)
I'm all out, since yesterday.

ASPEN
Lemme check how much I have.

WOMAN
Bless you.

Aspen sets her pack down on the ground, now much lighter, landing with a light thud. She pulls out a bottle from the side pocket. It's a quarter filled. She hands it to her.

ASPEN
Here.

The woman reaches out to grab the bottle. She opens it and fills her bottle. Aspen raises her eyebrows in annoyance, but relaxes quickly. The woman raises the bottle to drink from it.

ASPEN
(reluctantly)
You can have a drink from my bag if you want. To save that water for later.

The woman stops herself.

WOMAN

I don't mean to take any more water, I
already took a lot.

(making a face)

Sorry.

ASPEN

(more open)

Its no problem, I have a lot left.

She picks her bag up and walks it over next to the woman. She
grabs a blue tube sticking out the side of the bag.

ASPEN

Here.

The woman puts the tube to her mouth, drinking. She takes a
big gulp.

The woman puts her hands together, and bows a little.

WOMAN

Thank you so much.

Aspen grabs her bag, crouching down, and picking it up with
her usual 1,2,3. Aspen waves at the woman.

ASPEN

Have a good day, nice to meet you.

The woman waves back. Aspen walks away, back on the trail.

CUT TO:

22 EXT. TRAIL - LATER

Aspen is walking down through a valley. Trees grow at the
bottom, standing greener and taller than the vegetation
around it.

She's walking carelessly, almost flailing. One step right in
front, another off to the side, the next on the inside. She
takes an almost trips. Her faces fills with fear. She manages
to balances herself and come to a stop. She takes her bag
off, sitting on rock nearby.

From one of her bag pockets she pulls out a Cliff Bar. She
opens it and begins to eat it, leaning back against the rock.
She takes a deep breath. A beat. Exhales.

In the background over the ridge not to far away, a person

can be seen walking. Coming closer.

Aspen looks up, noticing something. The woman waves at her, much closer now.

WOMAN
(waving)
Hello again.

Aspen waves at her.

WOMAN
Does the break feel good.

Aspen faces lazy smiles, and nods.

WOMAN
Can you hear it?

The woman points down towards the tall trees.

WOMAN (CONT'D)
The water will feel so nice.

She thinks, staring at the sky.

WOMAN
Well, I'll see you on the trail. Bye.

The woman walks away. Aspen eats the last bit of her Cliff Bar, and taking a sip from her water tube.

Staring out across the landscape. Looking up to the ridge, a mountain lion walks, along the crest. It stops, turns to look out into the valley. A beat. It walks out of sight behind the ridge

CUT TO:

23 EXT. TRAIL - LATER

Aspen can now hear the river loudly, and clearly. The trees around her get taller, the vegetation gets greener. Almost crowding the path. As the river comes into view, she walks off the trail, towards it.

Pushing through the thicket, she comes to the river bank, a small stone beach. Looking around the trees hug the river, flowing slowly but carry lots of water. She turns to see the same woman as before, close by, she's naked. Showering.

Aspen notices that she has a penis. She quickly turns to look away. She makes a slight sound. The woman notices.

WOMAN

I'M SORRY! I DIDN'T SEE YOU THERE!

The woman walks over to her stuff and grabs a grey towel wrapping herself in it.

Aspen sits down, looking the other way. Taking out her water bottle, and taking her shoes and socks off. She walks over to the river, opens her bottle and begins to fill her water bottle.

She takes it out of the water, and closes it. She stands, her feet in the water, looking down stream. A beat.

Grass rustling can be heard, getting louder and louder. The woman walks through thicket, now clothed.

WOMAN

Sorry, I didn't think anyone was watching.

Aspen turns to face the woman.

WOMAN

The water here isn't the cleanest. I wouldn't recommend drinking it. It can give you stomach mushrooms.

ASPEN

Oh.

The woman sets her bag down, taking out a thick straw from one of its pockets. She hands it to Aspen. Aspen walks out of the water towards her.

WOMAN

Here.

Aspen grabs it.

ASPEN

(reading the label)
What is it?

WOMAN

A life straw.

ASPEN

Life straw.

WOMAN (CONT'D)

You can suck through that and it will filter your water.

ASPEN

I cant take it, its yours. I bet you need it just as much as I do.

WOMAN

I don't require a lot of water.

Aspen puts the straw in her bags side pocket.

WOMAN (CONT'D)

I realized, I never caught your name?

ASPEN

(quickly and quietly)

Aspen.

WOMAN

Sorry, could you repeat.

Aspen hesitates for a brief moment.

ASPEN

(a little louder)

Aspen.

WOMAN

ASPEN! Oh, what a beautiful name! I'm Dani. Nice to formally meet you Aspen.

(mini pause)

Do you have any more walking for today?

ASPEN

Yeh, a few more miles maybe.

The woman reaches into her pocket, pulling out a joint and holding it up.

DANI

You want to smoke?

SONG: "Soldier,Poet,King" begins to play. Softly at first.

CUT TO:

24 EXT. TRAIL - NIGHT

Close up of Dani hitting the joint. Music is now full volume. She passes the joint to Aspen.

Wide shot of their camp site. Aspen's tent is up, they are sitting on large stones, around a small fire.

Aspen takes a big hit from the joint, causing her to cough. She tries to hold it in by closing her mouth, but it too hot. Smoke begins coming out of her nose and mouth.

DANI
Whoa there, take it easy.

ASPEN
(still coughing)
Im in cloud nine right now.

Dani looks at Aspen, giving her a soft smile. They stare at each other. Dani moves her gaze to the river. Only the sound of the flowing water can be heard.

Dani exhales a short breath.

DANI
Wanna join me?

Dani stands up and walks over to the water's edge.

ASPEN
Are you kidding, I'm gonna become an icicle.

Dani reaches her hand into the water, moving it around slowly. Letting the water flow through her fingers.

DANI
It's not that bad.

Dani begins disrobing. Tossing her clothes over to the grass patch up the beach. In the dark Aspen can only see the back of her body, her bare butt.

She jumps in, diving into the water like a salmon. She disappears under the water. Aspen looks, waiting for her to come up. A beat.

Bubbles begin to rise, slowly. Larger and larger bubble begin coming out. Dani's head pops out, standing in the river, water level at her shoulders. She waves to Aspen,

"join me".

DANI
Come, come. It's not that bad.

Aspen takes a small rip of the joint.

ASPEN
I don't have a swim suit.

DANI
You don't need one. Skinny dip. No one
is watching.

Aspen shakes her head.

DANI
Suit yourself.

Dani turns around, stands up and dives back into the water.
Close up of Aspen's profile, ripping the joint.

CUT TO:

25 EXT. TRAIL - MORNING

CAMERA shows same wide. A bear is now rummaging through her bag. Clawing at it, gnawing at it, trying to get it open. It snorts, most likely smelling food.

ZZZZIIIPP. The sound of a zipper being opened.

CAMERA is inside the tent, looking at Aspen unzipping the tent "window".

Noticing the bear, panic creeps over her face immediately. She zips it back up slowly, trying to make as little noise as possible. The bear continues trying to breach the bag.

ASPEN
(under hear breath)
Oh my god. What do I do?

Aspen sits there, looking into space. She unzips the window open, a small sliver to see.

ASPEN
(quietly)
A grizzly.

She zips the window back up.

ASPEN (CONT'D)
 (quietly, frustrated)
 Fuck!

The wide shot again. Aspen slowly unzips the tent door, just enough so she can squeeze through. She steps out, wearing a pair of white slippers.

She walks slowly around the tent opposite to the bear. She grabs a rock. She throws it off to her right. Peaks around the tent. The bear reacts to the rock landing, but doesn't move. It returns to scavenging.

She grabs another rock and throws it, this time much closer to the bear. The bear moves back, looking up towards the tent. Aspen ducks. It sees nothing and goes back to the bag, finally pulling the top of the bag off, ripping a strap. It sticks its nose inside, smelling.

Aspen more worried, acts. She steps out standing on her tippy toes, her hands raised in the air. Waving them around.

ASPEN
 (yelling wildly)
 ARRRGHHHHH!! RRRRRRRHRHRHH!!

The bear, in a quick shock stumbles back, "afraid". The bear looks at Aspen. A bag of dried food in its mouth.

ASPEN (CONT'D)
 (with anger)
 AHHHHGHGHG! AAARRRHFFF!

Aspen begins walking towards it, slowly, step by step. She is still on her tippy toes. On one step she hits a pebble dead on, hurting her foot, and making her drop of her tippy toes.

ASPEN
 RRRRAAGHHH! AAAAGGGHHG!!

The bear places a paw forward, Aspen takes a step back, afraid now. It begins walking slowly, stepping onto top of the bag, walking towards her.

ASPEN (CONT'D)
 (with less vigor)
 RRrraaAAAHGGggh!

The bear keep walking, step after step. Aspen begins trodding backwards, putting space in between them. The bear starts walking faster, he's found a much better meal.

Aspen panicked, turns around and begins to run. The bear begins its pursuit, moving into a jog. A massive fur ball, yet incredibly agile. She runs as hard as she can, never looking back.

Appearing around a bend she notices a person. The person is KYLE, 23, a short and skinny man, with good muscle tone. He is wearing a light blue jacket and dark brown shorts. Noticing the Aspen and the bear, he quickly takes out his gun, pointing it directly at Aspen's face.

KYLE
GET DOWN!

Aspen looks back, the bear is closer. She tries to speed up.

KYLE
GET THE FUCK DOWN!

Aspen looks at the man. His eyes stern and pale.

KYLE (CONT'D)
NOW!

Aspen drops to the ground immediately.

BANG!! BANG!! The man fires the gun.

The bear makes a low growl screech. It turns left and runs into the woods. Aspen watches it disappear into the trees.

BANG!!! The man fires a round in the air.

She's startled by the third shot, getting up from the ground.

ASPEN
Thank you.

KYLE
Have to be careful, we are in bear territory.
(Gesturing to her campsite)
Need any help?

ASPEN
I should be fine, don't think it ate much of my food, so there's not much to clean up.
(mini pause)
Thank you though.

She walks towards her campsite, turning around to wave at the man. People talking comes in earshot, growing louder. Around the bend the Kyle came from appear 5 more people, all walking and talking. Two of the come up to Kyle. One is Gabby, 25, a large and muscular woman, wearing a tank top, and green cargo pants. Behind her is Joe, 23, a well sized person, with long blond hair down to their shoulders. They are wearing a Spirited Away t-shirt, and camo knee length shorts.

GABBY

Did you get anyone?

KYLE

Scared it off.

(pointing at Aspen)

Almost got himself killed

JOE

Kyle, when can we stop for food.

Kyle looks at his watch.

KYLE

We can stop now if you want.

Person #1 shyly nods there. Kyle points at Aspen

KYLE (CONT'D)

We can ask if he wants to join us

CUT TO:

The group walk up to Aspen's campsite

KYLE

Want to join us for lunch?

ASPEN

Lunch? I just woke up.

(mini pause)

Besides, its not even noon yet.

KYLE

It's one fifty five.

ASPEN

(stunned)

What!? Really!?

Kyle leans in, showing Aspen his wristwatch.

ASPEN
(annoyed)
I just got up.
(mini pause)
Fuck.

Kyle points to Aspen's bag, and the ripped bags of food all over the place.

KYLE
Is any of it still good?

ASPEN
There's still a few good ones.
(mini pause)
There's also a few ripped bags but I think they're still good if we eat them now.

CUT TO:

Aspen and the rest of the group are sitting, down in an oblong-esque shape. Starting from Aspen, and going to the left. Joe, Kyle, Ida, 23, a smaller woman wearing a blue bandana. Poppy, Gabby, Emil, 19, a young man looking ready for anything.

Everyone but Kyle and Ida are eating from the bear ripped dried food bags. Kyle is eating a banana.

JOE
(to Aspen)
You came up here without a bear canister, or a bear bag?

ASPEN
Didn't know we needed them. I left all the food in my bag.

KYLE
You need to get one ASAP.

GABBY
Agreed, without one, you'll be dead by Yosemite... actually... gimme a sec.

Gabby gets up, walking over to her bag.

JOE
I realize we never introduced ourselves.

(extending out a hand)
 Im Joe, nice to meet you.

Aspen freezes up for a moment, slowly extending out her hand.
 Gabby starts walking back, holding a black sewn bag, and a backpack on her back.

ASPEN
 Im Ash-

Gabby hands Aspen the bag.

GABBY
 Here, take this. We have an extra one.

Joe looks at Gabby with annoyance on their face. Gabby takes the pack of her back.

GABBY (CONT'D)
 A here's a backpack, to replace your torn one.

ASPEN
 Oh, thank you.

She grabs the two items.

ASPEN (CONT'D)
 Are you sure?

POPPY
 They were Lucky's. Better to give them to someone who can use them

GABBY
 Less weight we have to carry.

Aspen holds up the black bag.

ASPEN
 What's this?

POPPY
 Th-

Make sure you tie a good knot, so it doesn't fall down, or a bear tries to push it loose.

GABBY
 Its a bear bag. You put you food in there, or anything you don't want a bear rummaging through, and toss it over a tree. You let it hang.

Aspen looks at her with confusion.

POPPY

Im serious, its happened to me.

KYLE

What about food? How much do you have left?

ASPEN

A few more bags, probably last me two or three more days.

KYLE

You have anyone that can mail you things. We're only about two days out from Walker Pass.

ASPEN

My phones dead, and I bet their's no signal.

POPPY

We have a SAT phone.

Kyle shoves his hand into his bags side pocket.

POPPY (CONT'D)

Well, Kyle does.

Kyle hands Aspen a large black and yellow phone, looks almost like a Nokia.

ASPEN

Do I just dial the number?

POPPY

Yep.

Aspen gets up, dialing number on the keypad. She points away, asking permission to take the call away from the group. Kyle nods.

CAMERA stays with the group as she walks away from them.

CUT TO:

26 EXT. LILLI'S HOUSE - DAY

CAMERA zoomed into a white door, only the peep hole and room number 213 visible. A hand knocks on the door.

KNOCK! KNOCK!

WOMAN (O.S.)

Coming!

The door swing open. Standing there is Lilli, 22, short hair, almost a pixie cut. She's wearing a black Dracula t-shirt with a light gray cardigan, dark blue jeans and socks.

TAYLOR

Hey Lilli, is Asher here.

LILLI

(surprised)

Oh, hey Mr. Green... No.

(thinks for a second)

They left yesterday.

TAYLOR

I called the Go Sushi Go, he was supposed to start today but didn't show.

LILLI

Strange.

TAYLOR

Can I come in?

LILLI

(hesitantly)

Sure.

Lilli moves out of the way, gesturing to Taylor to come in. Taylor walks in.

27 INT. LILLI'S APARTMENT - DAY

TAYLOR

Thank you.

LILLI

You... You want something to drink?

TAYLOR

Water, thank you.

Lilli walks down the hall and out of sight into the kitchen. Taylor slowly walks towards the living room, looking around.

Pictures of Lilli with her family, Lilli and Aspen at Santa

Monica Pier, Lilli holding a dead rattlesnake, Lilli, Aspen, and Hazel getting a manicure, a drawing of a great blue heron signed '*For the best friend ever - Aspen*'.

Lilli comes back with a glass of water and a cup of coffee.

TAYLOR

Do you know where he could be?

Lilli hands the glass to Taylor.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)

Thank you.

Lilli sits down on the couch, Taylor on a white fuzzy chair across from her, separated by a small coffee table.

LILLI

Not the slightest idea.

Taylor eye brows raise slightly, he doesn't buy that answer.

TAYLOR

Im sure he must have said something.

Lilli pouts her lips and shrugs her shoulder, 'I don't know'.
Worry begins to grow in Taylor face.

TAYLOR

(a little worried)

Did he say anything about leaving?
Permanently?

LILLI

I think she-

Lilli catches herself, covering her mouth.

LILLI (CONT'D)

They said something about leaving.

Taylor gets up in a hurry, rushing. Panic and fear taking over. His breath shortening and quickening.

TAYLOR

(stressed)

Thank you. I have to-

LILLI
They're on the PCT.

Taylor stops, looking over at Lilli, doing a big sigh. His breathing relaxing.

TAYLOR
Where is he now?

LILLI
Don't know.

TAYLOR
(annoyed)
I think you do know.

Lilli stares at him. No answer.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
Lilli I need to find him, he could hurt himself. I need to protect him.

LILLI
(stern and confident)
She is perfectly capable.

TAYLOR
(accentuating the HE)
HE, needs my help.

LILLI
NO, what she needs is time alone. Time to reflect, relax and be herself.

Taylor in a fit of minor rage, ignores her and walks towards the door, slamming the door behind him.

CUT TO:

28 INT. ASPEN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Aspen is in her room, getting dressed looking at herself in the mirror. She has small eyeliner wings and minuscule amounts of blush. She is wearing well ironed, matte black pants that run to her down to her ankles and white socks. She is buttoning her salmon colored shirt.

She puts on a pair of black ballet flats. Looking at herself in the mirror.

TAYLOR (O.S.)
(through the door)
Asher! Ready?

ASPEN
Almost!

She keeps looking in the mirror.

TAYLOR (O.S.)
We still have to pick up Lilli!

Aspen takes off the flats.

ASPEN
Alright. Coming!

She puts the flats in her closet, placing a large jacket over them. Next to them she grabs a black pair of tennis shoes. She puts them on and walks out the door.

CUT TO:

29 INT. CAR INTERIOR - CONTINUED

Aspen and Taylor are in the car. Taylor is driving, and Aspen is looking in the pull down mirror, wiping at her face. Removing the small amounts of make-up she has on.

TAYLOR
You sure you don't want to put on the
shirt I brought?

Aspen looks at her dad, staring at him with dead eyes.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
It would look really good on you.

Taylor reaches his hand towards the backseat, not lifting his eyes from the road. Prodding around trying to find it.

ASPEN
(begrudgingly)
I already have a shirt.

Taylor grabs the shirt, holding it up, showing Aspen.

TAYLOR
That one feels a bit... I don't know,
feels a bit girly. Doesn't frame your
figure well.

Aspen rolls her eyes, she's not pleased.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
People are not gonna take you serious.
(holding up the shirt again)
This is how you get the girls.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
Dressing nice and making a good
impression.

Aspen doesn't respond, looking out the window, eyes transfixed on the bright lights as they whoosh by, listening to the sound of cars coming and going. Her mind spinning in a million directions, conflict in her eyes. Two beats.

TAYLOR
You can ask out Lilli.

ASPEN
She's my best friend.

TAYLOR
I know, but at a certain age, when people start to develop feelings for each other. They want to be more than just friends, and its totally normal.

ASPEN
I don't want a girlfriend...

TAYLOR
How do you know, you've never had one.

ASPEN
(in a stern tone, but not yelling)
I don't want a girlfriend!
(reluctantly, more timidly)
I want to be a girl.

TAYLOR
That will pass.

ASPEN
(frustrated)
No, it wont.

TAYLOR
It will, you feel this way because you've never been with a girl.

ASPEN
No I!- TAYLOR (CONT'D)
Once you've had sex you'll
see I'm right.

It will change you.
Dad!

Aspen turns around, giving her back to her dad.

TAYLOR
Im serious. You could do it with
Lilli, I bet she is also ready to have
sex, and would love to do it with you.

ASPEN
(flabbergasted)
Dad! Stop!

TAYLOR
OK, ok, it doesn't have to be Lilli.
(pause)
But you do need to have sex.

Taylor await s response, Aspen doesn't turn around.

TAYLOR (CONT'D)
We could hire a prostitute.

Aspens face lights up, whipping around to face her dad.

ASPEN
WHAT THE FUCK DAD!

CUT TO:

30 EXT. TRAIL - DAY

Aspen is walking, now surrounded by taller, greener trees.
The hills hiding in between the leaves. She is wearing her
skirt.

Aspen hears faint foot step sounds, faint murmurs. She
becomes incredibly worried, taking deep breaths of angst.

ASPEN
(under her breath, barely audible)
Breath, Breath, they don't care...
They'll walk right by.

The CAMERA shows two young men, in their mid to late 20's
come into view. They notice Aspen in front of them, she's not

to far in front.

HIKER #1
(signaling with his head)
Look... What do you think she is?

HIKER #2
I cant even see her face, how am I
supposed to rank?

HIKER #1
I say from behind a five.

The CAMERA is now looking at Aspen, the hikers are within
earshot of her.

HIKER #2
A six? I bet she's a seven.

Aspen cracks a small smile, getting the urge to look back.

HIKER #1
(gesturing with his hand)
Look at those hips, theirs barely an
ass.

Her smiles drops, lowering her head. The hikers are right
behind her.

HIKER #2
What's in front is what really
matters.

They walk past her, taking a glance back once their a few
steps ahead.

Both hikers eyes blow up.

HIKER #1
Never mind...

They turn around looking away, Hiker #1 lowers his voice so
Aspen doesn't hear it, but she does.

HIKER #1 (CONT'D)
More like a one.

HIKER #2
(trying to be less subtle)
More like a weirdo.

They speed up their pacing, their snickering and giggling getting softer as they get further away.

The muscles in Aspens face all drop. All glee and hope vanishes from her eyes, stopping, standing still staring at the ground.

ASPEN
YOU DISGUSTING FUCK!!

Aspen stomps her foot on the floor.

BANG!! A gunshot is heard, Aspens body drops to the ground.

DATH-THUMP!! Aspen is seen holding a gun above her dead body. She points the gun at her head again, firing four more rounds into her head. A beat.

Aspen is back standing on the path. With angry vigor she shoves the skirt of her waist, letting it hit the ground and kicking it off the path.

ASPEN
(pissed off)
Fucking freak.

She starts kicking rocks as hard as she can. On one kick she swings so hard she almost falls back. All along repeating

ASPEN
(over and over again, with minor variations)
Stupid, stupid, stupid! You deserve to die. You useless sack of fuck.

Rocks fly out in every direction, high speed soccer balls.

On one she kicks it hard straight against a tree. TAACK!

Her foot comes down, placing her foot down she lands on a loose slab of rock, slipping and landing on a large rock beside her, backpack first.

POP!!

CUT TO:

31 EXT. TRAIL - NIGHT

Wide shot of Aspens campsite, her tent set out on the ground, not yet standing. Aspen is crouched down to a pile of sticks.

CAMERA is now right next to Aspen. A small flame sits at the heart of the wooden pile. She blows into pile, causing the fire to grow. Every blow the lit wood burns brighter and brighter, enlarging the flame until it starts to light the larger sticks and logs around it.

The corners of Aspens mouth rise slightly, an almost fake smile.

Aspen walks over to her bag, opening the top. She takes her jacket off, setting it down on the flatten tent. She starts taking things out of the bag, clothes, cooking tools, food bags. She takes out the food bags one by one. Chicken Noodle Soup, Beef Stew, Beef Lasagna. Nothing she likes, she keeps digging. At the bottom of her bag she sees two more food bags and her crumpled skirt. Starting into the bag for a while, contemplating.

She takes out a bag of Chicken and Mashed Potatoes. Grabbing a gas canister and a *stove spigot*, and walking over to the fire.

She attaches the spigot onto the gas canister. Pulling a lighter from her pocket she turns the gas on and lights it.

SIZZZZZZZ SSSZZIP The gas catches fire, a large blue flame. She turns the knob, easing the flame to a small almost ember. She sets her water cup atop the small flame. The water begins to heat up.

She sits in silence, staring at the bonfire. The flame grows, flickers, crackles, changes, dies down and starts up again. A stead cycle. Thinking, contemplating, changing her hand positions, indecisive.

She gets up walking over to her bag, pulling out her skirt. Holding it up to the light, swaying in the light breeze.

She takes her pants off, putting on the skirt. She walks over to her chair and sits back down, the water now boiling. She opens the food bag, grabs the water cup and pours some in, stirring with a fork. Then closing the bag and setting it down on the floor. Once again staring at the flame, content creeping up her face, into her cheeks and eyes.

The fire crackles and faint hum of crickets echoes. Two beats

POPPY (O.S.)
(in the background)
Hey, we know you.

Aspen looks up to see Kyle, Poppy, _____ walking towards her. She panics immediately, looking around for a sweater, something to cover her skirt. Nothing, her jacket is too far to reach. Aspen shyly waves at the group, taking a deep breath.

GABBY
Love your skirt.

KYLE
It's really pretty.

ASPEN
(shyly, barely audible)
Thank you.

JOE
(gesturing with their hand)
Can we sit?

ASPEN
Sure... not sure there's any real
seats.

JOE
The ground works just fine.

The group sits down in a circle around the now larger bonfire.

POPPY
What was your name? Ash... something like th-

ASPEN
Aspen...
(pointing to Poppy, Emil, and Ida)
I realize that I didn't catch your
names.

POPPY
Im Poppy,
(pointing)
This is Emil and this Ida

Emil and Ida wave at Aspen.

ASPEN
Nice to meet you... well formally.

---NOT DONE---

CUT TO:

32 EXT. HIGHWAY *5* - NIGHT

Taylor is on the highway, few cars drive past, almost desolate. He pulls off the highway, *Exit 20 to Santa Clarita*.

33 EXT. *THE WILD BAR-LOCO* - CONTINUED

Taylor pulls into the parking lot of a rustic looking bar, standing alone on the streets, its neighboring buildings a lot apart from it.

He gets out of the car and walks into the bar.

34 INT. THE WILD BAR-LOCO - CONTINUED

The bar is lively, people are drinking and talking. There is a stage with drum set and instruments set up for a performance.

The bar is almost empty, eight stools and one is taken. Taylor walks over, sitting down on a stool far from the other person. He raises his hand to call the bartender.

BARTENDER
What will we be having to tonight?

TAYLOR
Do you have any food?

BARTENDER
We have nachos, quesadillas, wings,
fries,
(doing circles with his hands)
et cetera...

TAYLOR
Uhh... Ill have some... Do you have
lemon pepper wings?

BARTENDER
We have more like salt and pepper.

TAYLOR
Ill have that, thank you.

BARTENDER
Coming right up.

Taylor turns around to see people walking onto the stage, grabbing their instruments, and setting up for a performance. People cheer and applaud.

CAMERA stays on Taylor's POV. The LEAD SINGER walks up to the mic.

LEAD SINGER
Thank you everyone for coming here
tonight, hope we can make this a
special one to remember.

The Lead Singer turns around, signaling her band to different positions.

The Lead Singer takes a deep breath, only visible to Taylor. She taps her feet gently. They start playing, a vibrant rock song. People cheer as they start. Taylor sits and listens, enjoying the music as it goes on.

Another man walks into the bar, catching Taylor attention. The man walks over to the bar, sitting on the stool next to Taylor, he is not to happy about it. The man raises his hand to call the bartender, ordering a drink. The bartender walks away, and the man turns around to watch the performance.

The two men sit quietly listening. Two beats.

The man leans over to Taylor, extending out his hand.

MAN
Im Jordan.

TAYLOR
(apprehensibly)
Taylor, nice to meet you.

Taylor goes back to viewing the show, ignoring the man.

JORDAN
(pointing at the stage)
Thats my daughter, the one on the
guitar.

Taylor responds nothing, listening.

JORDAN (CONT'D)
Haven't seen her perform live in
years. Not since she was little.
(a pause)
She's beautiful is she not?

Taylor acknowledges Jordan, turning around to look at him.

JORDAN (CONT'D)
Do you have a daughter?

Taylor looks at Jordan, contemplating.

TAYLOR
I have a son.

JORDAN
How old?

TAYLOR
Nineteen

JORDAN
She just turned twenty nine.
(a beat)
Are you close with your boy?

TAYLOR
(hesitantly)
No. Not since his mom died.

JORDAN
Im sorry.

TAYLOR
Thank you.

JORDAN (CONT'D)
I haven't talked to her in ten years.
She still hates me. She probably would
be really mad if she saw me here, but
I wanted to see her perform. At least
one more time.

TAYLOR
She plays really well.

JORDAN
Were you planning on staying long?
Their last song is a good one.

The two men once again sit in silence, smiling a little. They listen to the music, now swaying and moving their body to the beat, enjoying themselves a bit more.

The bartender arrives with the food and drinks, setting them on the table. The two men turn around, to eat and drink. They talk to each other now more like new friends.

CUT TO:

The band plays their last few notes, ending on a high note with vigor and strength.

The crowd erupts in cheers, applauses and whistles. Jordan and Taylor stand up to clap, a big smile on Jordans face. On stage Jordans daughter notices her dad standing at the back, and quickly walks off stage.

JORDAN

Oh god, better get going before she yells at me for being here.

Taylor opens his mouth, but before anything can be said Jordan is walking towards the door. Taylor sets a twenty dollar bill on the table, and walks after him.

Before Jordan can reach the door his daughter, MABEL, 29, hugs him stopping in tracks, his face fills with surprise and fear.

MABEL

Thank you for coming.

JORDAN

Ohh...

She squeezes her hug, snuggling her head into his chest. Jordan opens his mouth to say something, but instead hugs he back, squeezing tight, he smiles.

Taylor smiles a little, walking past them towards the door.

TAYLOR

Nice to meet you Jordan.

JORDAN

Leaving already? This is my daughter Mabel.

Mabel waves at him?

TAYLOR
You played beautiful Maple... good
luck.

Taylor opens the door to leave.

MABEL
Thank you.

JORDAN
Bye. Nice to meet you.

Mabel grabs Jordan's hand dragging him.

MABEL
(to Jordan)
Come, meet my bandmates.

CUT TO:

35 INT. CAR INTERIOR - NIGHT

Taylor gets into his car, sitting in silence. His mind racing, his eyes glittering with the changing neon sign. Two beats. He pulls out of the parking lot, and onto the street.

His phone lights up, a text. He grabs it and reads it. Lilli: She is a few days from Walker Pass, you can meet her there.

At the same moment he doesn't notice the red light, crossing into the intersection at the same time a car driving really fast t-bones him.

CRIIEASSHHH!!!!

The windows shatter and the car spins out of control.

CUT TO:

END HERE FOR NOW

36 EXT. TRAIL - DAY

She continues walking with them learning from them, she starts to warm up, even opens up with one of them who tells everyone. But they love her for it even though she's embraced, and in a moment of fear they tell her their stories, which turn out to be quite the strange shit. Mom story moment.

This will be multiple scenes as they start to show more of who they are and their motives which become more and more stange, but yet they are supper nice. The group is staying because something happens to one of their members.

37 EXT. TRAIL - DAY

Aspen encounters Dani again, and she this time opens up and asks questions, and finally bring up her dad. She encourages but doenst push. Aspen is not wanting to go bcak.

38 EXT. PASSING THINGA - DAY

ARrive at the mail place and see Lillis stuff and letter. The group meets her there. They say not to go back to dad.

39 EXT. TRAIL - DAY

Aspen encounters Dani again, and she this time opens up and asks questions, and finally bring up her dad. She ecnourages but doenst push. Aspen is not wanting to go bcak. Same thing but different flavor. Rethink this maybe.

40 EXT. KENNEDY MEADOWS - DAY

She arrives, and meets the group there, who already got their earlier.